

for Winamp already, such as SqrSoft Advanced Crossfading Output, which ensures hours of uninterrupted music. It automatically detects the end of an audio stream and the beginning of the next track on your playlist, and cuts out the silence between them. The Gapless Audio Output plugin also provides the same feature. With the MP3 Output plugin, you can encode MP3 files directly from Winamp, which means you don't need a separate tool for ripping CDs. The Output Stacker plugin lets you use multiple output plugins together. This is very useful for a perfect audio experience, since no single plugin has all the enhancement features. Thus, you can mix the Crossfading Output plugin with the Direct-Sound output plugin and save money on a DJ at your next party. Or better still, use the DJamp plugin that uses Microsoft Agent and Text To Speech technology to provide an animated talking DJ—when Winamp finishes a song, DJamp displays a character that says a few words before playing the next song. The comments are configurable and can be in sequence or random.

Video for your PC

If you have a DVD player, get the CyberLink PowerDVD XP (www.gocyberlink.com).

Anatomy of Codecs

A codec (encoder-decoder) is an algorithm used to compress and decompress a file. Multimedia files in raw format are unmanageably huge. Unlike regular compression algorithms, codecs compress a file, yet allow them to be played back in regular media players—the decoder is bundled with the encoder, so the player simply picks up the correct codec for decoding the media file on the fly while it is playing. Again, unlike compression algorithms, codecs do not completely preserve the original image, audio or video—some parts of it are dropped to save space. Thus, as more data is dropped, so is the quality and file size. GIF and JPEG are compression algorithms for bitmap images. There are several codecs for audio and video, but the best ones are MP3 (MPEG II Layer 3) for audio and DivX (www.divx.com) for video. These afford the highest quality playback with compression ratios averaging around 10:1 (a 10 MB raw file can be compressed to a 1 MB encoded file without much noticeable loss in quality).

MUSICMATCH Jukebox

MUSICMATCH Jukebox (www.musicmatch.com) is a complete multimedia suite for all your audio requirements. You can play, rip and burn MP3s and audio CDs, and transfer songs to MP3 players. It can even record from tapes! mp3PRO

enhances the music quality in real-time. The software supports creation of CD labels and inlay cards with up to 150 track titles. You can even broadcast your playlist. The song catalogue and media management features are probably the

best—Super Tagging gives you faster, more accurate results for finding information about your tracks. You get names of

your favourite artistes, tracks and albums, and you can even automatically search and



The complete audio solution for your desktop

tag your tracks in just one click.

MUSICMATCH can keep track of all your downloaded files by monitoring certain folders. You can now set up multiple folders to synchronise with your music library.



Enhance your movie experience with PowerDVD

This is probably the most versatile DVD player with a whole load of features. This completely skinnable player supports DTS Digital Surround Sound and Dolby Pro Logic II to deliver the most rich and lively 5.1 channel audio experience, even if the original source was not encoded for 5.1 channel output. The evolved screen-capture feature lets you save high-quality snapshots from video. PowerDVD XP supports all current DVD formats such as DVD Video, DVD Video Recording, cDVD, miniDVD, etc. It can also play back video files from DVD-ROM, DVD-

ROM/RW combo, DVD-RAM, DVD-R/RW and DVD+RW drives.

You can avail a whole suite of software from www.afterdawn.com/software/, especially cool utilities for ripping DVDs. SmartRipper is a free DVD ripper that can extract VOB files from DVDs. It comes with an easy interface and automatically detects and reads the DVD, calculates the required drive space, splits VOB files per chapter and more. It also displays statistics such as length, size, and bitrates for every chapter or selection. aMPEG2Avi GUI is a great package for converting VOB files to AVIs. It contains pretty much all the software required for DVD to DivX

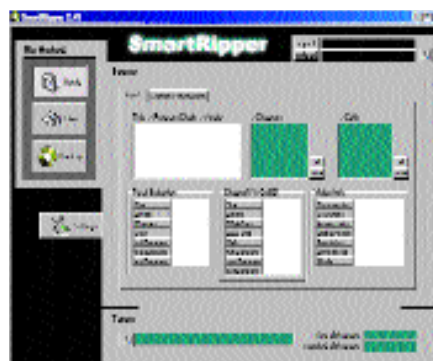


DivX: an easy way to encode video

conversion from DVD rippers to bitrate calculators.

EasyDivX (easydivx.does.it) is a free tool that encodes AVI files using the DivX codec. It supports DVD ripping and conversion to DivX AVI, MP3 or AC-3, making it a must-have for anyone who wants to rip DVDs, store movies on the hard disk or burn them on to CDs.

For burning VCDs, you just need the



SmartRipper rips DVDs to VOB files